

PERCEIVED COACHABILITY

WHY SOME ATHLETES
GET MORE CHANCES



IT'S NOT FAVORITISM. IT'S COACHABILITY.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Why Some Athletes Get More Chances

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The Gen Z Stare and What It Costs

Coming up.

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When Feedback Feels Like Attac

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Teaching Athletes to Ask for F

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Coachability as Character

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

ATHLETES WHO GET MORE CHANCES
TO MAKE MISTAKES ARE NOT THE
FAVORITE — THEY ARE THE MOST
COACHABLE.

Coachability isn't talent. It's not effort. And it's definitely not being perfect. A player is labeled uncoachable when feedback is given repeatedly and there is no visible attempt to apply it.

— COACHABILITY IS VISIBLE · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE COACHABILITY SIGNAL

EVERY TIME YOUR ATHLETE
RECEIVES FEEDBACK, SHE IS
SENDING A VISIBLE SIGNAL AND
COACHES READ IT.

- Coachability is not about talent it's about visible response to feedback
- Coaches give more opportunities to athletes whose response signals are open
- An uncoachable label is not permanent but it must be actively changed

— COACHABILITY IS A SKILL. IT CAN BE LEARNED. IT MUST BE SHOWN.

WHAT BLOCKS COACHABILITY

MISUNDERSTANDING

The athlete doesn't understand the feedback and doesn't know how to say so.

FEAR

Fear of failure or embarrassment causes the athlete to shut down instead of engage.

ENVIRONMENT MISMATCH

The athlete has never been taught how to receive feedback without interpreting it as attack.



READING THE SIGNAL

IN PRACTICE

After the coach gives feedback, watch: does your athlete nod, try the correction, ask a question?

WATCH FOR

The Gen Z stare blank expression that reads as dismissive but may be processing.

THE SHIFT

From responding naturally to coaching yourself to respond visibly — nod, say 'got it,' try it immediately.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

YOU ARE ALWAYS SENDING A SIGNAL
TO YOUR COACH. THE QUESTION IS:
WHAT DOES IT SAY?

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE SIGNAL LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, PRACTICE ONE VISIBLE COACHABILITY SIGNAL.

- ✓ After the next feedback moment, nod and say 'got it' even if you're still processing
- ✓ Make one visible attempt to apply the feedback in the next rep
- ✓ Ask one clarifying question if feedback is unclear instead of staying silent
- ✓ Notice how the coach's tone shifts when the signal is positive



PERCEIVED COACHABILITY

THE GEN Z STARE
AND WHAT IT COSTS



IT'S NOT DISRESPECT. BUT IT READS THAT WAY AND THAT MATTERS.



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THE GEN Z COMMUNICATION STYLE
MINIMAL RESPONSE, NO
PUNCTUATION, INSTANT AND BRIEF
IS NOT DISRESPECTFUL. BUT ON A
VOLLEYBALL COURT WITH AN OLDER
COACH, IT LOOKS LIKE IT IS.

Our kids grew up communicating with screens. Screens don't talk back. But coaches do. And they were trained in a world where communication was reciprocal facial expression, verbal acknowledgement, body language. The gap between those two worlds is costing your athlete opportunities.

— INTENT IS NOT THE SAME AS IMPACT · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE COMMUNICATION GAP

YOUR ATHLETE IS NOT WRONG
FOR HOW SHE COMMUNICATES.
BUT SHE MAY BE INVISIBLE AND
THAT HAS CONSEQUENCES.

- Intent: she heard the feedback, processed it, plans to try it
- Impact: the coach received silence and reads it as disengagement
- Bridge: one small visible signal closes the entire gap

— IN A WORLD WHERE IMPACT IS CURRENCY, INTENTION IS NOT ENOUGH.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE TRANSLATION

SCREEN COMMUNICATION

Abbreviated, minimal, asynchronous perfectly efficient in one context.



COURT COMMUNICATION

Real-time, reciprocal, emotional the coach needs to know you received the signal.

THE BRIDGE

One word, one nod, one immediate try this is the translation that costs nothing and changes everything.



CLOSING THE GAP

IN PRACTICE

Role play at home: you give feedback, she responds with one of the three bridge signals.

WATCH FOR

Her default in high-stakes moments stare, withdrawal, or short replies and coach it before the court.

THE SHIFT

From expecting coaches to understand her communication style to learning the one required here.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

YOU DON'T HAVE TO CHANGE HOW
YOU COMMUNICATE EVERYWHERE.
YOU HAVE TO LEARN THE LANGUAGE
OF THE ROOM YOU'RE IN.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE TRANSLATION

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, PRACTICE THE THREE BRIDGE SIGNALS.

✓ Define the three signals: nod, say 'got it,' and immediately try the correction

✓ Practice all three in a low-stakes setting before the next practice

✓ After practice, ask: 'Did you use any of the bridge signals today?'

✓ Notice does the coach's engagement level shift when she uses them?

PERCEIVED COACHABILITY

WHEN FEEDBACK
FEELS LIKE ATTACK

03

THE FEEDBACK ISN'T ABOUT YOU. TRAIN YOUR NERVOUS SYSTEM TO KNOW THAT.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

WHEN FEEDBACK FEELS LIKE AN
ATTACK, THE BODY SHUTS DOWN
BEFORE THE BRAIN CAN PROCESS
WHAT WAS ACTUALLY SAID.

Athletes who have had negative experiences with coaching often develop automatic shutdown responses. The current coach is not the problem. The nervous system has linked feedback to danger and that association has to be deliberately rewired.

— THE BODY LEARNS BEFORE THE MIND DOES · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE SHUTDOWN PATTERN

A SHUTDOWN RESPONSE TO
FEEDBACK IS NOT ATTITUDE. IT'S
A NERVOUS SYSTEM PROTECTING
ITSELF FROM A THREAT THAT
MAY NO LONGER EXIST.

- Recognize: the shutdown is a pattern, not a personality trait
- Separate: this coach, this moment, this feedback separate from the past
- Build: safety in new feedback environments through small, positive repetitions

— THE NERVOUS SYSTEM LEARNS SAFETY THROUGH EXPERIENCE, NOT THROUGH INSTRUCTIONS.

THE PATTERN

THE LINK

If past feedback came with humiliation or fear, the nervous system links feedback = danger.



THE TRIGGER

Current feedback activates past memory the response is to the past, not the present.

THE REWIRE

New, positive feedback experiences even small ones begin to separate the past from the present.

REBUILDING SAFETY

IN PRACTICE

Find one coach or trusted adult who can give feedback in a low-stakes, warm environment regularly.

WATCH FOR

Signs of nervous system response: going quiet, rigid posture, withdrawal, over-explaining.

THE SHIFT

From labeling her as sensitive or dramatic to identifying a specific pattern and addressing it.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

SHE IS NOT BEING DRAMATIC. HER
NERVOUS SYSTEM IS BEING HONEST
ABOUT WHAT IT LEARNED. REWIRING
TAKES TIME AND REPETITION.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE REWIRE

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, CREATE ONE SAFE FEEDBACK MOMENT.

- ✓ Give one piece of feedback in a warm, low-stakes setting not during practice or post-match
- ✓ Watch for shutdown signals and name them kindly: 'I noticed you went quiet are you okay?'
- ✓ Follow every piece of feedback with one acknowledgment of what she's doing right
- ✓ Track over four weeks: is the shutdown window getting shorter?



PERCEIVED COACHABILITY

TEACHING ATHLETES
TO ASK FOR FEEDBACK



THE MOST COACHABLE ATHLETES SEEK FEEDBACK BEFORE THEY RECEIVE IT.



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Coachability as Character

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HEAR THIS ONCE

WAITING TO BE COACHED IS
PASSIVE. SEEKING FEEDBACK IS A
COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE.

Athletes who ask good questions about their own performance are telling coaches: I want to improve. I am paying attention. I am invested. This signal is rare and coaches notice it immediately.

— SEEKING FEEDBACK IS A SKILL, NOT A PERSONALITY · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE ATHLETE WHO ASKS FOR FEEDBACK SHIFTS FROM BEING COACHED TO CHOOSING HER DEVELOPMENT.

→ After practice: 'Is there one thing I should focus on this week?'

→ After a mistake: 'What would you have wanted to see there instead?'

→ After a game: 'What did you notice about my game today?'

— ASKING FOR FEEDBACK IS NOT WEAKNESS. IT IS THE FASTEST PATH TO GROWTH.

THE QUESTIONS

GENERIC VS. SPECIFIC

'How am I doing?' is easy to deflect. 'What's one thing I could clean up this week?' requires an answer.



TIMING

After practice or the next day never in the middle of a match or a correction.

FOLLOW-THROUGH

Asking a question and then not applying the answer is worse than not asking.

COACHING THE QUESTION

IN PRACTICE

Role play asking for feedback at home so it feels natural when she does it with a coach.

WATCH FOR

Whether she freezes when a coach unexpectedly asks her a question about her own game.

THE SHIFT

From waiting to be told what to do to actively directing her own development.



SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE ATHLETE WHO SEEKS FEEDBACK
IS TELLING HER COACH: I AM A
SERIOUS INVESTMENT. COACHES
RESPOND TO THAT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE SEEKER LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, PRACTICE ASKING ONE FEEDBACK QUESTION.

- ✓ Prepare one feedback question together before the next practice
- ✓ Have her ask it to her coach, a trainer, or a trusted teammate
- ✓ Debrief: what did she learn? How did the conversation feel?
- ✓ Build one feedback question into her post-practice routine



PERCEIVED COACHABILITY

COACHABILITY
AS CHARACTER

05

HOW YOU RECEIVE FEEDBACK OFF THE COURT IS HOW YOU RECEIVE IT ON IT.

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HEAR THIS ONCE

COACHABILITY IS NOT A
VOLLEYBALL SKILL. IT IS A LIFE
SKILL THAT SHOWS UP ON THE
VOLLEYBALL COURT.

The athlete who can receive criticism from a coach, process it without defensiveness, and apply it with humility is also building the character that will serve her far beyond volleyball. This is not just about playing time.

— COACHABILITY BUILDS CHARACTER · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE TRANSFER

The way your athlete receives feedback from a coach is the way she will receive it from a boss, a partner, and life.

→ Coachability transfers: classroom, workplace, relationships all require receiving feedback well

→ The habits built now will follow her into every room she enters

→ This is the long game develop the skill because the person it builds matters most

— YOU ARE NOT JUST RAISING AN ATHLETE. YOU ARE RAISING A PERSON.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE TRANSFER ZONES

CLASSROOM

Can she receive a correction from a teacher without shutdown or defensiveness?

RELATIONSHIPS

Can she hear feedback from a teammate without making it personal?

WORKPLACE (LATER)

Will she be able to take direction and criticism as a tool, not a threat?



BUILDING FOR LIFE

IN PRACTICE

Point out when she handles feedback well in a non-volleyball context — make the transfer explicit.

WATCH FOR

Whether coachability skills are transferring out of the gym — that's the real sign of growth.

THE SHIFT

From 'work on your coachability so you get more playing time' to 'this is who you're becoming.'



SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE ATHLETE WHO LEARNS TO BE
COACHED BECOMES THE ADULT WHO
KNOWS HOW TO GROW. THAT IS THE
REAL PRIZE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE CHARACTER LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, ACKNOWLEDGE ONE COACHABILITY MOMENT OUTSIDE OF VOLLEYBALL.

✓ Watch for one moment where your athlete receives feedback well outside the gym

✓ Name it explicitly: 'That was coachability did you notice that?'

✓ Connect it to what she's building on the court

✓ Celebrate the person, not just the player

